Rules

This is a detective game played entirely inside this PDF. Click the blue buttons to make your choices and move between pages.

Your inventory is shown at the top of every page. Some choices are greyed out until you are carrying the right item.

Page numbers are shuffled, so flipping ahead will not help you. Use the buttons, not the scroll bar.

There are 8 different endings. Some are triumphant. Some are educational.

Start game

Start

It is 3 a.m. Your phone buzzes on the nightstand: an alert from your homelab. Something is very wrong.

Open the dashboard

At the police station

A detective with a tired face takes your USB stick full of logs. 'We will be in touch,' she says. 'And your data? Is it safe?'

Tell her it is fully restored

Tell her honestly: a fifth is gone

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

Block unknown-7f3a

Blocked. A second later 'unknown-7f3b' appears. Then 7f3c. New hosts keep spawning, and they are not coming from the Internet. They are coming from inside your server.

Close all open ports on the router

Pull the Internet cable

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

- Reboot and hope for the best
- Ask the AI to fix its own mistake
- Boot the rescue USB

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, USB rescue stick

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Accuse Greg

'You think I would DDoS my own friend?!' Greg hangs up. Your phone shows one missed call from him and zero chances of more help tonight. You feel a little bad.

Check who is connected to the router

Close all open ports on the router

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Call Greg

Greg picks up on the ninth ring. 'It is 3 a.m. This better be a death.' You explain. He yawns. 'Turn it off and on again. I am going back to sleep.'

Follow his advice: pull the plug

Read him the log lines (locked)

Hang up and close the ports

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

- Try to revert using the AI method
- Inspect what the AI command changed
- Wait for the system response

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

At the police station

A detective with a tired face takes your USB stick full of logs. 'We will be in touch,' she says. 'And your data? Is it safe?'

Tell her it is fully restored (locked)

Tell her honestly: a fifth is gone

Block the User-Agent

One line in the reverse proxy config. The traffic drops for exactly three seconds, then returns with a new User-Agent: 'GregBot/1.1'. Someone is mocking you.

Check who is connected to the router

Close all open ports on the router

At the police station

A detective with a tired face takes your USB stick full of logs. 'We will be in touch,' she says. 'And your data? Is it safe?'

Tell her it is fully restored (locked)

Tell her honestly: a fifth is gone

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB (locked)
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Inventory: Backup key, Restored data

ENDING 4 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Justice, With Gaps

Kev gets a stern talk from a very tired detective. Your lab recovers, with a fifth of its memories missing. You learn to love the numbers 3-2-1, and you never forget them again.

Play again

Clean slate

The system is clean, finally. SSH works, the OS is healthy. But Docker is empty: no containers, no databases, no media server. You have a clean slate and a very long list.

- [ ] Check the backups
- [ ] Rebuild from your compose files
- [ ] Hunt for the attacker
- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

Report Kev

You write a thorough report: logs, timestamps, the README, the Reddit thread. The officer reads it twice, sips her coffee and says: 'Wow. Please do not hack anyone back.'

Hand over the evidence at the station

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Hack him back

You fire a stress-testing tool at his IP. It feels incredible for eleven seconds. Then you notice the IP belongs to a shared school router.

Keep going. He deserves it

Stop. Think

Talk to Kev

You type: 'Hi Kev. We need to talk.' A long pause. Then: 'omg pls dont call my mom'. He sounds exactly as scared as a sixteen-year-old should.

Offer him a deal

Tell him you are calling the police

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Talk to Kev

You type: 'Hi Kev. We need to talk.' A long pause. Then: 'omg pls dont call my mom'. He sounds exactly as scared as a sixteen-year-old should.

Offer him a deal

Tell him you are calling the police

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket is a different story, if you can unlock it.

- Pay the ransom
- Search for the offsite backup key
- Decrypt the offsite backup
- Back to the container status

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Wipe and reinstall

You boot an installer, delete every partition and watch a clean OS go on. The backdoor is gone. So is everything else, until you bring it back.

Restore the offsite backup

Rebuild from the GitHub mirror

Rebuild by hand, from memory

Unplug the fridge

The fridge was running firmware from 2014 and was indeed part of a botnet, but a very small part. The attack does not even notice. Your ice cream begins to melt for nothing.

Block unknown-7f3a

Close all open ports on the router

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Inventory: Backup key, Kev's handle

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Trace the connection

Behind the proxies: a residential IP, then a student account at a school in the next county. Kev is, at the very most, sixteen years old.

Send him a message

Report him to the police

Hack him back

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Kernel reinstalled

The package cache comes through. A fresh kernel sits in /boot again. Before rebooting, you notice the disk still has other surprises hiding in it.

Scan the disk for hidden tools

Reboot right now

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response (locked)

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

- Pull the plug and rethink
- Boot the rescue USB
- Rage-quit the whole hobby

Greg wakes up

Silence. Then: 'That is NOT my bot. Check your IoT junk, this looks like a Mirai variant.' He sounds fully awake now, and slightly offended.

- Check who is connected to the router
- Ask why he knows so much about this
- Close all open ports on the router

Restore the offsite backup

On a clean system the bucket finally gives up your data from last Tuesday. Photos, databases, the media library, byte by byte. It takes hours. It is the best hours of your week.

Verify the checksums

Start the containers right away

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket was untouched, if you can unlock it.

Decrypt the offsite backup (locked)

Search the attic for the key

Pay the ransom

Back to the lab

ENDING 8 OF 8 - FAILURE

The Wrong Tool

You took down a school network three days before exams. Kev gets a warning. You get a very serious letter from a lawyer. Greg offers to be a character witness. It is not enough.

Play again

The deal

You offer: help rebuild and harden the lab, write a full report on how he got in, and apologize to Greg. In exchange: no police, no mom. He says yes in under two seconds.

Shake on it

Rebuild from compose files

Your compose files lived in a Git repo. On this server. You stare at the empty disk and a cold realization settles in. Also, this server is still full of Kev.

Wipe the server and start fresh

Rebuild right here, right now

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username (locked)

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Kev returns

At 5:12 a.m. the honeypot lights up. Someone logs in and starts exploring. He types very slowly. 'ls'. 'cd'. 'ls' again. He seems nervous.

Trace the connection

Open a chat window in his terminal

Hack him back

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 8 OF 8 - FAILURE

The Wrong Tool

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Play again

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Decrypt the offsite backup (locked)

Search the attic for the key

Pay the ransom

Back to the lab

Containers offline

SSH access is restored, and the base OS is healthy. However, Docker is completely empty—all your containers, databases, and media servers failed to start up automatically.

- Check the backups
- Search the server for traces
- Run a rootkit scanner
- Rebuild from your compose files
- Burn it all down and walk away

Clean slate

The system is clean, finally. SSH works, the OS is healthy. But Docker is empty: no containers, no databases, no media server. You have a clean slate and a very long list.

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- [ ] Hunt for the attacker
- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB

Remove Internet connection

You rip the ethernet cable out of the router. The blinking lights go quiet. But the attack was already writing to your disks when the link dropped.

Check the damage

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Greg arrives

Twenty minutes later Greg is at your door with two coffees, a spare SSD and a look that says 'I told you so'. He has also forgiven you for anything you said earlier.

- Let him help with the backups
- Let him help you hunt the attacker
- Send him home and keep going

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

3-2-1 and a test

Three copies. Two kinds of media. One offsite. And, for the first time in your life, an actual restore test. Past you would be proud. Future you will be grateful.

Close the laptop. It is morning

Not done: find who did this

Block unknown-7f3a

Blocked. A second later 'unknown-7f3b' appears. Then 7f3c. New hosts keep spawning, and they are not coming from the Internet. They are coming from inside your server.

Close all open ports on the router

Pull the Internet cable

Clean slate

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- [ ] Check the backups
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- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

Inventory: empty

ENDING 3 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Redemption Arc

Kev writes a forty-page report, fixes every hole he used, and now maintains your lab on weekends. Greg gets a public apology. The fridge lives on a VLAN. Everyone is safer, a bit embarrassed and strangely proud.

Play again

3:33 a.m.

A cron job nobody wrote wakes up. Every fan on the rack changes pitch, the console fills with red text, and /boot disappears. The DDoS was only a smokescreen: the real attack was already inside.

Open the console

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Firewall logs

Between thousands of junk requests hides a single successful SSH login at 02:41, using a key you did not create.

Check the authorized_keys file

Check the server console

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

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- Send him home and keep going

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

- Pull the plug and rethink
- Boot the rescue USB
- Rage-quit the whole hobby

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The deal

You offer: help rebuild and harden the lab, write a full report on how he got in, and apologize to Greg. In exchange: no police, no mom. He says yes in under two seconds.

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3:33 a.m.

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Open the console

Containers offline

SSH access is restored, and the base OS is healthy. However, Docker is completely empty—all your containers, databases, and media servers failed to start up automatically.

- Check the backups
- Search the server for traces
- Run a rootkit scanner
- Rebuild from your compose files
- Burn it all down and walk away

The IoT VLAN

The smart fridge, the TV and the cat feeder are moved into a room with no windows and no keys. The fridge is not happy about it, but then again, it never was.

Back to the lab

Inventory: Backup key, Restored data

ENDING 1 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Full Recovery

Your lab is back, your data is back, and Kev's case sits in a folder somewhere in the county. You set up alerting, expire Greg's old key and hang a sign over the rack: 'THE RESCUE USB IS NOT DECORATION.' Pixel sleeps on the server again.

Play again

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

- Try to revert using the AI method
- Inspect what the AI command changed
- Wait for the system response

Hack him back

You fire a stress-testing tool at his IP. It feels incredible for eleven seconds. Then you notice the IP belongs to a shared school router.

Keep going. He deserves it

Stop. Think

Who is kev_the_kernel?

The username shows up on a forum, a game server and a school coding club page. His avatar is a cat in sunglasses. His latest post: 'anyone know how to bypass a firewall? asking for homework'.

Set a honeypot to catch him

Send him a message

Report the username

Inventory: Backup key, Kev's handle

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

The DHCP list

Fourteen devices: laptop, phone, TV, the cat feeder, the smart fridge, and one host called 'unknown-7f3a' that you have never seen in your life.

- [ ] Unplug the smart fridge
- [ ] Block unknown-7f3a
- [ ] Check the server room camera
- [ ] Close all open ports on the router

Inventory: Ai answer, USB rescue stick

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Mrs. Nagy's Wi-Fi

Mrs. Nagy opens the door in a dressing gown, holding a rolling pin. After a lecture about what time it is, she gives you the password: 'macska1234'. Her router is, somehow, very secure.

Download a rescue ISO and flash a USB stick

Thank her and go home

Unplug the fridge

The fridge was running firmware from 2014 and was indeed part of a botnet, but a very small part. The attack does not even notice. Your ice cream begins to melt for nothing.

Block unknown-7f3a

Close all open ports on the router

Trace the connection

Behind the proxies: a residential IP, then a student account at a school in the next county. Kev is, at the very most, sixteen years old.

Send him a message

Report him to the police

Hack him back

Kev returns

At 5:12 a.m. the honeypot lights up. Someone logs in and starts exploring. He types very slowly. 'ls'. 'cd'. 'ls' again. He seems nervous.

Trace the connection

Open a chat window in his terminal

Hack him back

Set a honeypot

You leave a fake server with a fake SSH door 'accidentally' open, full of files named passwords_final_v2.xlsx. Now you wait.

Wait for Kev

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Traces

In /root: README_KEV.txt. 'gg ez. i was never here. - kev_the_kernel'. Next to it a hidden cron job, an unknown kernel module and a very smug piece of ASCII-art cat.

Check the backups

Run a rootkit scanner

Back to the container status

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Rebuild on the infected host

The containers come up one by one. So does Kev's backdoor, now with a front-row seat to your brand-new database passwords. At dawn every service is sending spam to the entire Internet.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Pull the plug and walk away

The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

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You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

3-2-1 and a test

Three copies. Two kinds of media. One offsite. And, for the first time in your life, an actual restore test. Past you would be proud. Future you will be grateful.

Close the laptop. It is morning

Not done: find who did this

Containers offline

SSH access is restored, and the base OS is healthy. However, Docker is completely empty—all your containers, databases, and media servers failed to start up automatically.

- Check the backups
- Search the server for traces
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- Rebuild from your compose files
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Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

- Boot the rescue USB
- Admit you have no USB stick
- Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

The AI apologizes

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Hack him back

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Keep going. He deserves it

Stop. Think

Hidden tools

Hidden in /etc and /usr/lib: a logic-bomb cron job, a rogue SSH key and a text file called README_KEV.txt: 'gg ez - kev_the_kernel'. Whoever he is, he is proud of it.

Document it, delete it and reboot

The attic

Dust, a plastic Christmas tree and a shoebox. Inside, a laminated card in your handwriting: 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY - bucket homelab-bkp'. Past you really was a genius.

Go back to the backups

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, random guy from reddit

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

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Not done: find who did this

Server room camera

On the feed: Pixel the cat, asleep on top of the server, one paw on the keyboard. Suspicious, but she has been there since 2 a.m. and has an alibi: she is a cat.

Back to the DHCP list

Close all open ports on the router

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

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You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

- Search for the username
- Look through his connection logs
- Set a honeypot

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

Clean slate

The system is clean, finally. SSH works, the OS is healthy. But Docker is empty: no containers, no databases, no media server. You have a clean slate and a very long list.

- [ ] Check the backups
- [ ] Rebuild from your compose files
- [ ] Hunt for the attacker
- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

Inventory: empty

ENDING 8 OF 8 - FAILURE

The Wrong Tool

You took down a school network three days before exams. Kev gets a warning. You get a very serious letter from a lawyer. Greg offers to be a character witness. It is not enough.

Play again

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

- Pull the plug and rethink
- Boot the rescue USB
- Rage-quit the whole hobby

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

Pull the plug and rethink

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Rage-quit the whole hobby

Inventory: Kev's handle, Restored data

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

The other comments

The top comment, from a moderator: 'Boot a live USB. Never paste scripts from strangers.' Kev's reply was posted forty seconds after you. Nobody diagnoses a kernel in forty seconds. Unless they already knew.

- Run Kev's script anyway
- Boot the rescue USB
- Make a rescue USB

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

- Reboot and hope for the best
- Ask the AI to fix its own mistake
- Boot the rescue USB (locked)

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

No USB. Make one

Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Call Greg

Greg picks up on the ninth ring. 'It is 3 a.m. This better be a death.' You explain. He yawns. 'Turn it off and on again. I am going back to sleep.'

Follow his advice: pull the plug

Read him the log lines

Hang up and close the ports

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

The IoT VLAN

The smart fridge, the TV and the cat feeder are moved into a room with no windows and no keys. The fridge is not happy about it, but then again, it never was.

Back to the lab

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB (locked)
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Trace the connection

Behind the proxies: a residential IP, then a student account at a school in the next county. Kev is, at the very most, sixteen years old.

Send him a message

Report him to the police

Hack him back

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Restore onto the infected server

Eight hours later every file is back. You sleep like a baby. At 3 a.m. your phone buzzes: everything is encrypted again. The backdoor was just waiting for fresh data.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Throw the server out of the window

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Harden the lab

Key-only SSH. fail2ban. Automatic updates. You feel the smug satisfaction of locking the door after the burglar has already left, and you enjoy every second of it.

Move the IoT junk to its own VLAN

Back to the lab

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response (locked)

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response (locked)

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Rebuild by hand

You rebuild from memory. You forget three passwords, two port numbers and why Nextcloud needed that one weird cron job. After six hours half the services work.

Keep going until it all works

Pull the plug on this madness

Harden the lab

Key-only SSH. fail2ban. Automatic updates. You feel the smug satisfaction of locking the door after the burglar has already left, and you enjoy every second of it.

Move the IoT junk to its own VLAN

Back to the lab

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Rebuild from compose files

Your compose files lived in a Git repo. On this server. You stare at the empty disk and a cold realization settles in. Also, this server is still full of Kev.

Wipe the server and start fresh

Rebuild right here, right now

Rebuild by hand

You rebuild from memory. You forget three passwords, two port numbers and why Nextcloud needed that one weird cron job. After six hours half the services work.

Keep going until it all works

Pull the plug on this madness

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Inventory: Backup key, Restored data

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

- Boot the rescue USB
- Admit you have no USB stick
- Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Who is kev_the_kernel?

The username shows up on a forum, a game server and a school coding club page. His avatar is a cat in sunglasses. His latest post: 'anyone know how to bypass a firewall? asking for homework'.

Set a honeypot to catch him

Send him a message

Report the username

The rescue USB

The stick boots on the first try, which feels like a personal gift from past you. A live shell, a blinking cursor, and your dead disks waiting to be mounted.

Mount, chroot and reinstall the kernel

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

Rootkit scanner

The scanner takes forever, then prints one word in red: INFECTED. The kernel from the Reddit script carries a backdoor, and so does half of /usr/bin. Nothing on this machine can be trusted.

Wipe the server and reinstall

Check the backups

Back to the container status

The other comments

The top comment, from a moderator: 'Boot a live USB. Never paste scripts from strangers.' Kev's reply was posted forty seconds after you. Nobody diagnoses a kernel in forty seconds. Unless they already knew.

Run Kev's script anyway

Boot the rescue USB

Make a rescue USB

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB (locked)
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

- Pull the plug and rethink
- Boot the rescue USB
- Rage-quit the whole hobby

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Rebuild on the infected host

The containers come up one by one. So does Kev's backdoor, now with a front-row seat to your brand-new database passwords. At dawn every service is sending spam to the entire Internet.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Pull the plug and walk away

Inventory: Backup key, Restored data

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response (locked)

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

20% data loss

The ports are closed, but the attacker was already inside. A fifth of your files are gone or corrupted, and the system is acting strangely.

Look at the system more closely

Read the firewall logs

Rootkit scanner

The scanner takes forever, then prints one word in red: INFECTED. The kernel from the Reddit script carries a backdoor, and so does half of /usr/bin. Nothing on this machine can be trusted.

Wipe the server and reinstall

Check the backups

Back to the container status

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

ENDING 3 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Redemption Arc

Kev writes a forty-page report, fixes every hole he used, and now maintains your lab on weekends. Greg gets a public apology. The fridge lives on a VLAN. Everyone is safer, a bit embarrassed and strangely proud.

Play again

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

Kev returns

At 5:12 a.m. the honeypot lights up. Someone logs in and starts exploring. He types very slowly. 'ls'. 'cd'. 'ls' again. He seems nervous.

- Trace the connection
- Open a chat window in his terminal
- Hack him back

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Server room camera

On the feed: Pixel the cat, asleep on top of the server, one paw on the keyboard. Suspicious, but she has been there since 2 a.m. and has an alibi: she is a cat.

Back to the DHCP list

Close all open ports on the router

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Rebuild by hand

You rebuild from memory. You forget three passwords, two port numbers and why Nextcloud needed that one weird cron job. After six hours half the services work.

Keep going until it all works

Pull the plug on this madness

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Reboot right now

The system boots. Twenty minutes later the logic bomb you did not remove fires a second time and the kernel vanishes again. At least the rescue stick is still warm.

Open the console

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method

Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

Set a honeypot

You leave a fake server with a fake SSH door 'accidentally' open, full of files named passwords_final_v2.xlsx. Now you wait.

Wait for Kev

Restart

The BIOS splash screen appears. Services begin initializing one by one as the OS boots back up from disk.

Check the container status

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

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- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Rebuild on the infected host

The containers come up one by one. So does Kev's backdoor, now with a front-row seat to your brand-new database passwords. At dawn every service is sending spam to the entire Internet.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Pull the plug and walk away

Inventory: Backup key, Kev's handle, Restored data

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

Still attacking

The attack never stopped. Whoever is behind it is still hammering your lab, and the router is wide open again.

Close all open ports on the router

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket was untouched, if you can unlock it.

- Decrypt the offsite backup
- Search the attic for the key
- Pay the ransom
- Back to the lab

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket is a different story, if you can unlock it.

Pay the ransom

Search for the offsite backup key

Decrypt the offsite backup (locked)

Back to the container status

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB (locked)
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket was untouched, if you can unlock it.

- Decrypt the offsite backup
- Search the attic for the key
- Pay the ransom
- Back to the lab

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

No USB. Make one

Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

The deal

You offer: help rebuild and harden the lab, write a full report on how he got in, and apologize to Greg. In exchange: no police, no mom. He says yes in under two seconds.

Shake on it

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Checksums match

Every checksum matches. For the first time tonight something is exactly as it should be. But somewhere out there, kev_the_kernel is still laughing.

Hunt for the attacker

Harden the lab

Inventory: Backup key, Kev's handle, Restored data

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Clean slate

The system is clean, finally. SSH works, the OS is healthy. But Docker is empty: no containers, no databases, no media server. You have a clean slate and a very long list.

- [ ] Check the backups
- [ ] Rebuild from your compose files
- [ ] Hunt for the attacker
- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Harden the lab

Key-only SSH. fail2ban. Automatic updates. You feel the smug satisfaction of locking the door after the burglar has already left, and you enjoy every second of it.

Move the IoT junk to its own VLAN

Back to the lab

Inventory: Restored data

ENDING 4 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Justice, With Gaps

Kev gets a stern talk from a very tired detective. Your lab recovers, with a fifth of its memories missing. You learn to love the numbers 3-2-1, and you never forget them again.

Play again

Flash a rescue USB

At her kitchen table you download the ISO and flash it while Mrs. Nagy watches you like a hawk. Twenty minutes and one cookie later, you hold a bootable stick.

Go home and check the server

Reboot right now

The system boots. Twenty minutes later the logic bomb you did not remove fires a second time and the kernel vanishes again. At least the rescue stick is still warm.

Open the console

The attic

Same attic, same dust, same plastic tree. A laminated card: 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY'. You promise to buy past you a coffee.

Back to the backups

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

Accuse Greg

'You think I would DDoS my own friend?!' Greg hangs up. Your phone shows one missed call from him and zero chances of more help tonight. You feel a little bad.

Check who is connected to the router

Close all open ports on the router

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket was untouched, if you can unlock it.

Decrypt the offsite backup (locked)

Search the attic for the key

Pay the ransom

Back to the lab

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Harden the lab

Key-only SSH. fail2ban. Automatic updates. You feel the smug satisfaction of locking the door after the burglar has already left, and you enjoy every second of it.

Move the IoT junk to its own VLAN

Back to the lab

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Rebuild by hand

You rebuild from memory. You forget three passwords, two port numbers and why Nextcloud needed that one weird cron job. After six hours half the services work.

Keep going until it all works

Pull the plug on this madness

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

- Hit the physical power button to restart
- Wait in the dark
- Check your phone

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

No USB. Make one

Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Inventory: empty

ENDING 4 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Justice, With Gaps

Kev gets a stern talk from a very tired detective. Your lab recovers, with a fifth of its memories missing. You learn to love the numbers 3-2-1, and you never forget them again.

Play again

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

- Pull the plug and rethink
- Boot the rescue USB
- Rage-quit the whole hobby

Start the containers

docker compose up -d. Pi-hole, Jellyfin and Vaultwarden greet you like old friends. Three containers refuse to start because their images disappeared. You decide to check the data anyway.

Verify the checksums

Greg arrives

Twenty minutes later Greg is at your door with two coffees, a spare SSD and a look that says 'I told you so'. He has also forgiven you for anything you said earlier.

- Let him help with the backups
- Let him help you hunt the attacker
- Send him home and keep going

The rescue USB

The stick boots on the first try, which feels like a personal gift from past you. A live shell, a blinking cursor, and your dead disks waiting to be mounted.

Mount, chroot and reinstall the kernel

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Restore the offsite backup

On a clean system the bucket finally gives up your data from last Tuesday. Photos, databases, the media library, byte by byte. It takes hours. It is the best hours of your week.

Verify the checksums

Start the containers right away

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

Talk to Kev

You type: 'Hi Kev. We need to talk.' A long pause. Then: 'omg pls dont call my mom'. He sounds exactly as scared as a sixteen-year-old should.

Offer him a deal

Tell him you are calling the police

Restart

The BIOS splash screen appears. Services begin initializing one by one as the OS boots back up from disk.

Check the container status

Inventory: Ai answer, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

authorized_keys

Three keys. Yours. 'greg@old-laptop' from 2021. And one with the comment 'backup@localhost', added at 02:41 tonight.

- Remove the strange key
- Call Greg about his old key
- Check the server console

Restore onto the infected server

Eight hours later every file is back. You sleep like a baby. At 3 a.m. your phone buzzes: everything is encrypted again. The backdoor was just waiting for fresh data.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Throw the server out of the window

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

The IoT VLAN

The smart fridge, the TV and the cat feeder are moved into a room with no windows and no keys. The fridge is not happy about it, but then again, it never was.

Back to the lab

Homelab DDoS

Traffic graphs are through the roof. Thousands of requests per second are hammering your homelab. The router fans are screaming. You have to act now.

- Remove the Internet connection
- Close all open ports on the router
- Read the traffic logs first
- Call Greg, your sysadmin friend

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- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

The other comments

The top comment, from a moderator: 'Boot a live USB. Never paste scripts from strangers.' Kev's reply was posted forty seconds after you. Nobody diagnoses a kernel in forty seconds. Unless they already knew.

Run Kev's script anyway

Boot the rescue USB

Make a rescue USB

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Kernel reinstalled

The package cache comes through. A fresh kernel sits in /boot again. Before rebooting, you notice the disk still has other surprises hiding in it.

Scan the disk for hidden tools

Reboot right now

Rebuild on the infected host

The containers come up one by one. So does Kev's backdoor, now with a front-row seat to your brand-new database passwords. At dawn every service is sending spam to the entire Internet.

Wipe and reinstall for real

Pull the plug and walk away

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The IoT VLAN

The smart fridge, the TV and the cat feeder are moved into a room with no windows and no keys. The fridge is not happy about it, but then again, it never was.

Back to the lab

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

- Boot the rescue USB
- Admit you have no USB stick
- Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

Rootkit scanner

The scanner takes forever, then prints one word in red: INFECTED. The kernel from the Reddit script carries a backdoor, and so does half of /usr/bin. Nothing on this machine can be trusted.

Wipe the server and reinstall

Check the backups

Back to the container status

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

- Boot the rescue USB
- Admit you have no USB stick
- Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Rebuild from compose files

Your compose files lived in a Git repo. On this server. You stare at the empty disk and a cold realization settles in. Also, this server is still full of Kev.

Wipe the server and start fresh

Rebuild right here, right now

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open. 0.5 BTC is more than the server cost. Your finger hovers over the button. In your head Greg says: 'Never pay.'

Send the payment

Close the wallet

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

No internet

Silence. Without a connection you cannot look up fixes, ask for help or download anything. You are alone with the damage.

- Plug the ethernet cable back in
- Search your desk for anything useful
- Knock on Mrs. Nagy's door for Wi-Fi
- Wait for the sun to come up

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

Read the traffic logs

Every single request carries the same User-Agent: 'GregBot/1.0'. Greg is your friend. Greg is a sysadmin. Greg has a sense of humor. Or does he?

Block that User-Agent

Call Greg. Right now.

Close all open ports on the router

Hack him back

You fire a stress-testing tool at his IP. It feels incredible for eleven seconds. Then you notice the IP belongs to a shared school router.

Keep going. He deserves it

Stop. Think

Inventory: Kev's handle, Restored data

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket is a different story, if you can unlock it.

- Pay the ransom
- Search for the offsite backup key
- Decrypt the offsite backup
- Back to the container status

Decrypt the offsite backup

The key works. The bucket holds your data from last Tuesday: photos, databases, the media library. But the server in front of you is running a kernel that Kev wrote.

Restore onto this server right now

Wipe the server, then restore

The DHCP list

Fourteen devices: laptop, phone, TV, the cat feeder, the smart fridge, and one host called 'unknown-7f3a' that you have never seen in your life.

- [ ] Unplug the smart fridge
- [ ] Block unknown-7f3a
- [ ] Check the server room camera
- [ ] Close all open ports on the router

The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket was untouched, if you can unlock it.

- Decrypt the offsite backup
- Search the attic for the key
- Pay the ransom
- Back to the lab

The attic

Same attic, same dust, same plastic tree. A laminated card: 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY'. You promise to buy past you a coffee.

Back to the backups

Traces

In /root: README_KEV.txt. 'gg ez. i was never here. - kev_the_kernel'. Next to it a hidden cron job, an unknown kernel module and a very smug piece of ASCII-art cat.

Check the backups

Run a rootkit scanner

Back to the container status

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

20% data loss

A fifth of your files are gone or corrupted. The rest of the lab is cut off from the world.

Stay offline and think

Plug the ethernet cable back in

Inventory: Backup key, Kev's handle

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

Inventory: empty

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Rootkit scanner

The scanner takes forever, then prints one word in red: INFECTED. The kernel from the Reddit script carries a backdoor, and so does half of /usr/bin. Nothing on this machine can be trusted.

Wipe the server and reinstall

Check the backups

Back to the container status

Wipe and reinstall

You boot an installer, delete every partition and watch a clean OS go on. The backdoor is gone. So is everything else, until you bring it back.

Restore the offsite backup

Rebuild from the GitHub mirror

Rebuild by hand, from memory

Ask Reddit

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Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

The other comments

The top comment, from a moderator: 'Boot a live USB. Never paste scripts from strangers.' Kev's reply was posted forty seconds after you. Nobody diagnoses a kernel in forty seconds. Unless they already knew.

Run Kev's script anyway

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Make a rescue USB

Start the containers

docker compose up -d. Pi-hole, Jellyfin and Vaultwarden greet you like old friends. Three containers refuse to start because their images disappeared. You decide to check the data anyway.

Verify the checksums

Set a honeypot

You leave a fake server with a fake SSH door 'accidentally' open, full of files named passwords_final_v2.xlsx. Now you wait.

Wait for Kev

Set a honeypot

You leave a fake server with a fake SSH door 'accidentally' open, full of files named passwords_final_v2.xlsx. Now you wait.

Wait for Kev

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The local backups

Your NAS holds years of backups. All encrypted, with a note: 'Send 0.5 BTC for the key. You have 24 hours.' The offsite bucket is a different story, if you can unlock it.

Pay the ransom

Search for the offsite backup key

Decrypt the offsite backup (locked)

Back to the container status

The attic

Dust, a plastic Christmas tree and a shoebox. Inside: a laminated card in your handwriting. 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY - bucket homelab-bkp'. You had completely forgotten that you made one.

Go back to the server room

3-2-1 and a test

Three copies. Two kinds of media. One offsite. And, for the first time in your life, an actual restore test. Past you would be proud. Future you will be grateful.

Close the laptop. It is morning

Not done: find who did this

No USB stick

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Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

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- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Greg arrives

Twenty minutes later Greg is at your door with two coffees, a spare SSD and a look that says 'I told you so'. He has also forgiven you for anything you said earlier.

- Let him help with the backups
- Let him help you hunt the attacker
- Send him home and keep going

Wipe and reinstall

You boot an installer, delete every partition and watch a clean OS go on. The backdoor is gone. So is everything else, until you bring it back.

Restore the offsite backup (locked)

Rebuild from the GitHub mirror

Rebuild by hand, from memory

Search the desk

Under three tangled chargers you find a USB stick labelled 'RESCUE - tested never'. Past you was either a genius or an optimist. Behind it, a sticky note: 'check the attic'.

Climb up to the attic

Go back to the server room

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 4 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Justice, With Gaps

Kev gets a stern talk from a very tired detective. Your lab recovers, with a fifth of its memories missing. You learn to love the numbers 3-2-1, and you never forget them again.

Play again

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Send the payment

Close the wallet

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Inventory: Kev's handle

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

Connection logs

He came through three proxies and a Tor exit node. Professional? Or just someone who follows tutorials very carefully?

Set a honeypot

Back to the investigation

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Let him help with the backups

Let him help you hunt the attacker

Send him home and keep going

Close all open ports on router

You log into the router and shut every forwarded port: SSH, HTTPS, the Jellyfin stream, everything. The router is quiet for a moment, then the logs start scrolling again.

Check the damage

Check the server console

Read the firewall logs

Inventory: Restored data

ENDING 1 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Full Recovery

Your lab is back, your data is back, and Kev's case sits in a folder somewhere in the county. You set up alerting, expire Greg's old key and hang a sign over the rack: 'THE RESCUE USB IS NOT DECORATION.' Pixel sleeps on the server again.

Play again

Wipe and reinstall

You boot an installer, delete every partition and watch a clean OS go on. The backdoor is gone. So is everything else, until you bring it back.

Restore the offsite backup (locked)

Rebuild from the GitHub mirror

Rebuild by hand, from memory

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username (locked)

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

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Not done: find who did this

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

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The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

The rescue USB

The stick boots on the first try, which feels like a personal gift from past you. A live shell, a blinking cursor, and your dead disks waiting to be mounted.

Mount, chroot and reinstall the kernel

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

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- Let him help you hunt the attacker
- Send him home and keep going

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, USB rescue stick

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

The attic

Same attic, same dust, same plastic tree. A laminated card: 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY'. You promise to buy past you a coffee.

Back to the backups

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

ENDING 3 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Redemption Arc

Kev writes a forty-page report, fixes every hole he used, and now maintains your lab on weekends. Greg gets a public apology. The fridge lives on a VLAN. Everyone is safer, a bit embarrassed and strangely proud.

Play again

Report Kev

You write a thorough report: logs, timestamps, the README, the Reddit thread. The officer reads it twice, sips her coffee and says: 'Wow. Please do not hack anyone back.'

Hand over the evidence at the station

Kernel reinstalled

The package cache comes through. A fresh kernel sits in /boot again. Before rebooting, you notice the disk still has other surprises hiding in it.

Scan the disk for hidden tools

Reboot right now

Inventory: Ai answer, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

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Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

Pull the plug and rethink

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Rage-quit the whole hobby

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

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- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB (locked)
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

3-2-1 and a test

Three copies. Two kinds of media. One offsite. And, for the first time in your life, an actual restore test. Past you would be proud. Future you will be grateful.

Close the laptop. It is morning

Not done: find who did this

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open. 0.5 BTC is more than the server cost. Your finger hovers over the button. In your head Greg says: 'Never pay.'

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

3:33 a.m.

A cron job nobody wrote wakes up. Every fan on the rack changes pitch, the console fills with red text, and /boot disappears. The DDoS was only a smokescreen: the real attack was already inside.

Open the console

Who is kev_the_kernel?

The username shows up on a forum, a game server and a school coding club page. His avatar is a cat in sunglasses. His latest post: 'anyone know how to bypass a firewall? asking for homework'.

- Set a honeypot to catch him
- Send him a message
- Report the username

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Kernel deleted

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Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

- Try to revert using the AI method
- Inspect what the AI command changed
- Wait for the system response

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open again. You know this system is clean, which makes paying even sillier. Your finger hovers anyway.

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Inventory: Backup key, Restored data

ENDING 8 OF 8 - FAILURE

The Wrong Tool

You took down a school network three days before exams. Kev gets a warning. You get a very serious letter from a lawyer. Greg offers to be a character witness. It is not enough.

Play again

ENDING 2 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Phoenix

The photos are gone, the databases are gone. But the compose files are alive, the lab is new, and for the first time you have real backups. Starting over is the oldest homelab tradition there is.

Play again

At the police station

A detective with a tired face takes your USB stick full of logs. 'We will be in touch,' she says. 'And your data? Is it safe?'

Tell her it is fully restored

Tell her honestly: a fifth is gone

Inventory: empty

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

A clean boot

The BIOS splash, then the login prompt. No red text, no strange kernel modules. Services start one by one, politely, like a system with nothing to hide.

Check the container status

Kernel deleted

You open the console. The kernel has been deleted. The machine is still running from memory, but it will not survive a reboot. You need to get it back, and fast.

- Ask an AI how to recover the kernel
- Ask Reddit how to recover the kernel
- Boot the rescue USB
- Call Greg again
- Search the Arch wiki on your phone

Ask Reddit

You post on r/homelab with the title: 'PLEASE HELP MY KERNEL IS DELETED'. Almost instantly a user called kev_the_kernel replies with a helpful-looking shell script.

Execute the Reddit advice

Read the other comments first

Harden the lab

Key-only SSH. fail2ban. Automatic updates. You feel the smug satisfaction of locking the door after the burglar has already left, and you enjoy every second of it.

Move the IoT junk to its own VLAN

Back to the lab

Inventory: Ai answer, random guy from reddit

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

You unplug everything. The silence is wonderful. You sell the rack, buy a plant and discover that sunlight exists. You do not miss the 3 a.m. alerts. You do, slightly, miss the lab.

Play again

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

- Boot the rescue USB
- Admit you have no USB stick
- Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

The deal

You offer: help rebuild and harden the lab, write a full report on how he got in, and apologize to Greg. In exchange: no police, no mom. He says yes in under two seconds.

Shake on it

Decrypt the offsite backup

The key works. The bucket holds your data from last Tuesday: photos, databases, the media library. But the server in front of you is running a kernel that Kev wrote.

Restore onto this server right now

Wipe the server, then restore

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

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Play again

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

The IoT VLAN

The smart fridge, the TV and the cat feeder are moved into a room with no windows and no keys. The fridge is not happy about it, but then again, it never was.

Back to the lab

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

- Try to revert using the AI method
- Inspect what the AI command changed
- Wait for the system response

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username (locked)

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Something happened

The terminal flashes a cascade of cryptic messages. The screen freezes for a moment. You aren't entirely sure what just executed, but the system state has fundamentally shifted.

Try to revert using the AI method (locked)

Inspect what the AI command changed (locked)

Wait for the system response

The Arch wiki

Three hours of reading compressed into twelve minutes. Verdict: you need a live USB, a chroot and patience. It also says, in bold, not to run commands you do not understand.

- Boot the rescue USB
- No USB. Make one
- Ignore the bold text, ask an AI

Ask an AI

You paste the panic-induced error logs into an AI chatbot. It confidently outputs a multi-step kernel compilation and reinstallation command string. You copy-paste and execute it.

See what happens

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Plug back ethernet

The link light turns green again. For a few seconds everything looks fine. Then the traffic graph spikes.

Check the graphs

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Inventory: Kev's handle

ENDING 6 OF 8 - FAILURE

Paid and Played

The payment goes through. Nothing happens. Then a second note appears: 'Thanks! The price is now 1.0 BTC.' You are poorer, the data is still encrypted, and Kev has a new gaming PC.

Play again

Rebuild from compose files

Your compose files lived in a Git repo. On this server. You stare at the empty disk and a cold realization settles in. Also, this server is still full of Kev.

Wipe the server and start fresh

Rebuild right here, right now

Kernel panic

The machine boots, panics, reboots, panics. A loop. The fans spin up and down like a broken ventilator. Each cycle takes forty seconds, and your patience takes forty seconds less.

Pull the plug and rethink

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Rage-quit the whole hobby

Inventory: Ai answer, Backup key, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

Flash a rescue USB

The phone hotspot crawls, the ISO downloads, the progress bar lies about its percentage. Eventually you hold a bootable stick with a freshly written 'RESCUE' label.

Boot the rescue USB

Hidden tools

Hidden in /etc and /usr/lib: a logic-bomb cron job, a rogue SSH key and a text file called README_KEV.txt: 'gg ez - kev_the_kernel'. Whoever he is, he is proud of it.

Document it, delete it and reboot

Kernel deleted

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The attic

Dust, a plastic Christmas tree and a shoebox. Inside, a laminated card in your handwriting: 'OFFSITE BACKUP KEY - bucket homelab-bkp'. Past you really was a genius.

Go back to the backups

Everything goes black

The monitors click off. The server chassis fans wind down to complete silence. Total darkness fills the room.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Wait in the dark

Check your phone

The AI apologizes

'You are absolutely right, and I apologize!' it says, then offers a cleaner solution: 'rm -rf /boot /etc /var' followed by a fresh install. It sounds extremely confident.

Run it. It sounds confident

Check the Arch wiki instead

Who is kev_the_kernel?

The username shows up on a forum, a game server and a school coding club page. His avatar is a cat in sunglasses. His latest post: 'anyone know how to bypass a firewall? asking for homework'.

Set a honeypot to catch him

Send him a message

Report the username

Kernel panic

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- Pull the plug and rethink
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A new message

One new DM from kev_the_kernel: 'thx for the root password lol. have fun rebuilding'. He deletes the message while you are still reading it.

Hit the physical power button to restart

Inventory: Ai answer, USB rescue stick

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

Bricked

Nothing boots. Nothing mounts. Your disks hold a very organized pile of zeros. The AI would like to apologize again, but its server is not your server.

Play again

Inventory: empty

Hunt for the attacker

You have a README file, a forum name and a lot of anger. You open a terminal and a browser, and start digging.

Search for the username (locked)

Look through his connection logs

Set a honeypot

Kernel deleted

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Ask an AI how to recover the kernel

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Call Greg again

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Talk to Kev

You type: 'Hi Kev. We need to talk.' A long pause. Then: 'omg pls dont call my mom'. He sounds exactly as scared as a sixteen-year-old should.

Offer him a deal

Tell him you are calling the police

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

Set up proper, tested backups

Hunt for the attacker first

Inspect the damage

The AI built a kernel for the wrong CPU architecture, set the root password to 'password' 'for convenience' and disabled the firewall 'to avoid conflicts'. Impressive, honestly.

- Reboot and hope for the best
- Ask the AI to fix its own mistake
- Boot the rescue USB

The rescue USB

The stick boots on the first try, which feels like a personal gift from past you. A live shell, a blinking cursor, and your dead disks waiting to be mounted.

Mount, chroot and reinstall the kernel

Inventory: Backup key

ENDING 3 OF 8 - SUCCESS

Redemption Arc

Kev writes a forty-page report, fixes every hole he used, and now maintains your lab on weekends. Greg gets a public apology. The fridge lives on a VLAN. Everyone is safer, a bit embarrassed and strangely proud.

Play again

Reboot right now

The system boots. Twenty minutes later the logic bomb you did not remove fires a second time and the kernel vanishes again. At least the rescue stick is still warm.

Open the console

Survivors

On an old laptop and the attic Raspberry Pi you find 2019 photos, a database dump from March and half the media library. It is not much, but it is yours.

Rebuild every service

Clean slate

The system is clean, finally. SSH works, the OS is healthy. But Docker is empty: no containers, no databases, no media server. You have a clean slate and a very long list.

- [ ] Check the backups
- [ ] Rebuild from your compose files
- [ ] Hunt for the attacker
- [ ] Harden the lab
- [ ] Call Greg to come over

Greg, again

Greg answers on the first ring. Grumpy, but he cannot resist a broken kernel. 'Do NOT paste random commands. Boot a live USB, chroot in, reinstall from the package cache. Like a civilized person.'

Boot the rescue USB

Admit you have no USB stick

Ignore Greg and ask Reddit

The other comments

The top comment, from a moderator: 'Boot a live USB. Never paste scripts from strangers.' Kev's reply was posted forty seconds after you. Nobody diagnoses a kernel in forty seconds. Unless they already knew.

Run Kev's script anyway

Boot the rescue USB

Make a rescue USB

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Inspect what the AI command changed

Wait for the system response (locked)

Inspect the damage

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Reboot and hope for the best

Ask the AI to fix its own mistake

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Trace the connection

Behind the proxies: a residential IP, then a student account at a school in the next county. Kev is, at the very most, sixteen years old.

Send him a message

Report him to the police

Hack him back

Inventory: Kev's handle

ENDING 7 OF 8 - FAILURE

Touch Grass

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Play again

Flash a rescue USB

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The GitHub mirror

Three months ago you mirrored the repo to GitHub 'just in case'. The compose files are there. The data is not. Rebuilding means starting every service empty.

Rebuild every service from the mirror

See if any data survived

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Checksums match

Every checksum matches. For the first time tonight something is exactly as it should be. But somewhere out there, kev_the_kernel is still laughing.

Hunt for the attacker

Harden the lab

Reboot right now

The system boots. Twenty minutes later the logic bomb you did not remove fires a second time and the kernel vanishes again. At least the rescue stick is still warm.

Open the console

Rebuild the services

One by one the green lights appear: Jellyfin, Nextcloud, the databases. Empty, but alive. The dashboards look beautiful and hollow, like a brand new apartment.

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Inspect the damage

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Boot the rescue USB

Remove the key

You delete the key. The terminal answers: 'Connection closed by remote host.' He was already using something else, something much deeper than SSH.

Check the server console

Report Kev

You write a thorough report: logs, timestamps, the README, the Reddit thread. The officer reads it twice, sips her coffee and says: 'Wow. Please do not hack anyone back.'

Hand over the evidence at the station

Inventory: Ai answer, Kev's handle, USB rescue stick, random guy from reddit

ENDING 5 OF 8 - FAILURE

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Play again

No USB stick

'Then make one,' says Greg. 'You need a laptop, an ISO and a connection. Phone hotspot will do.' He hangs up to go back to bed. Again.

Tether your phone and flash a stick

Ask the AI instead

A clean boot

The BIOS splash, then the login prompt. No red text, no strange kernel modules. Services start one by one, politely, like a system with nothing to hide.

Check the container status

Pay the ransom

The wallet is open. 0.5 BTC is more than the server cost. Your finger hovers over the button. In your head Greg says: 'Never pay.'

Send the payment

Close the wallet

Run the command

The terminal scrolls for a very long time. Then it stops. Then the terminal itself disappears, because the thing that was running it no longer exists.

Look at what is left

Flash a rescue USB

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Boot the rescue USB

Kernel panic

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Kernel reinstalled

The package cache comes through. A fresh kernel sits in /boot again. Before rebooting, you notice the disk still has other surprises hiding in it.

Scan the disk for hidden tools

Reboot right now

The other comments

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Run Kev's script anyway

Boot the rescue USB (locked)

Make a rescue USB

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Back to the lab